ABOUT THE ORIGINAL STUDY

What do we know about the extent of teacher shortages nationwide? A systematic examination of reports of U.S. teacher shortages

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Why It Matters

Teacher shortages are widely reported, but inconsistent definitions and incomplete data make their scale difficult to assess. This study compiles and verifies state-level evidence on vacancies and underqualification, providing a nationwide baseline and showing why national totals alone cannot guide targeted policy responses.

Data and Sample

The study searches news reports and public agency records for all 50 states and D.C., with final verification completed in November 2023. It combines state reports, mostly from 2021–2022, with federal data; vacancy counts are available for 37 jurisdictions, with differing years and definitions limiting comparisons.

Key Findings

- The study documents at least 39,700 vacant teaching positions and approximately 288,000 positions filled by underqualified teachers. These are conservative estimates, not a complete count for a single school year.
- No usable vacancy estimate could be found for 14 states, which together enrolled approximately 30.47% of U.S. public school students. Missing data do not establish that vacancies are absent.
- The apparent severity of shortages changes substantially when vacancies are measured relative to student enrollment or the teacher workforce rather than as raw counts.
- Many states with low or unknown vacancy counts have large numbers of underqualified teachers. Vacancy and underqualification measure different staffing problems; credentials do not directly measure teacher effectiveness.

Policy Implications

- Make school-level teacher qualification data readily and promptly available so policymakers can identify where particular staffing needs exist and target investments.
- Maintain accessible data on job postings and unfilled teaching positions. Develop common definitions and collect detailed, comparable data annually.
- Report shortage counts alongside enrollment- or workforce-adjusted rates. Clearly distinguish vacancies from different forms of underqualification, and qualifications from effectiveness.

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